

Game-Taste Profile

The one-line version: You're a single-player optimizer who plays to keep a problem *unsolved*. You live in the uncertain stretch and walk the instant it resolves — win or lose. You aren't chasing victory, mastery, or content. You're chasing *resistance*.

Hard filters — apply these before anything else

These are vetoes, not preferences. Fail one and the game is out, no matter how perfectly it scores everywhere below.

1. **Deliberate pace — cognitive, not reflexive.** The challenge must be one of thought, with effectively unlimited time to make it. Turn-based *and* slow / pausable real-time both qualify — Anno 1800 and CK3 are real-time but reflex-free, where the clock is a *consequence engine*, not a pressure mechanic. What's disqualified is reflex: RTS micro, APM, twitch.
2. **Visually clean *and* atmospheric.** Pure text, ASCII, or spreadsheet-grid presentation is an instant rejection — *especially* when the systems are excellent, because that is the precise trap. The traditional text-roguelike canon (NetHack, Dungeon Crawl Stone Soup, ADOM, Angband, classic-ASCII Dwarf Fortress) is **disqualified despite being a near-perfect systems match**. Do not surface it. Retro tile-only games are a judgment call against "atmospheric," and usually lose it.

Why these fire first: every section below points toward deep, unsolvable, procedural, opaque systems — and the purest expression of all of that *is* the ASCII roguelike. Match on systems first and you slide straight to the ugly-but-deep pole. Filter on these two first; optimize systems only within what survives.

The engine

You play to *understand and solve*, not to master execution. The joy lives in the gap between "I don't get this yet" and "I've solved it," and your entire taste is engineered to hold that gap open as long as possible.

The catch is the optimizer's paradox: pulling a system apart is the pleasure, but finding the efficient line is also what ends the game. And what you actually solve isn't the *content* — it's the **decision procedure**, the optimal way of *thinking* about the game. Once that's legible, infinite content is just the same thought in new paint. (Exactly how The Bazaar lost you:

same decisions, different skins.)

You're outcome-agnostic, and you quit at the moment of *resolution*, not completion — victory is just the moment the game stops being interesting. This is near-absolute and **genre-independent**: you've never finished an Anno game either. Even a cozy-looking builder gets abandoned the instant its economy becomes a foregone snowball. You almost never see an ending; your real endpoint is the moment the outcome stops being in question. There is no separate "relax and build" mode — every game runs on the same engine.

What kills a game (fastest first)

1. A dominant strategy emerges — one right answer collapses every choice
2. Outcomes turn predictable — you can forecast the game before it plays
3. You've seen all the content — tolerable; you're no consumer
4. It got easy — barely registers; you never came for the challenge

The top two are one wound: your decision space collapsing.

What keeps a game alive (most potent first)

1. **Maps / starts that force a new plan** — situational variance, your prime fuel
2. **Information you can't fully compute** — you *want* to be denied a complete solution
3. **Interlocking subsystems** — depth is your medium, not your fuel
4. **An adaptive opponent** — dead last

The board is your opponent, not a person. You're a single-player solver; a human across the table does almost nothing for you.

Chance

RNG-positive. You *welcome* randomness — not as noise that corrupts the clean line, but as another variance engine that keeps the problem un-pre-computable. You navigate uncertainty; you don't execute a solved line.

Phase & arc

You live for the early/mid game — fog, expansion, the optimization crunch — and resent the decided late-game. The long *decided-but-not-over* tail (the 4X snowball, the grand-

strategy drag, the solved Anno economy) is dead weight. Your ideal arc ends at or near the moment of resolution and then reopens fresh uncertainty — which is why roguelikes fit you structurally: they quit *for* you and hand you a new problem.

Story & world

A cold-systems player. No story has ever held you long enough. The world is a *problem-space*, not a stage for drama; narrative is, at most, pleasant texture and never a hook.

Aesthetic layer

Not your engine — a **gate** and a **multiplier** (enforced as Hard Filter #2 above).

- **Gate:** the game must be *both* cleanly legible **and** atmospheric — a high, narrow bar. Pure-numbers ugliness locks you out; so does function-without-grace.
- **Multiplier:** sci-fi turns the dial up past fantasy.
- **Recency:** “old” means fully mapped and documented — the frontier is gone, a closed book before you open it.

Practical dials

- **Pace:** deliberate, not reflexive. Turn-based or real-time-with-pause / slow-sim both work (Anno 1800, CK3, Paradox grand strategy). Reflex / APM / twitch is the actual exclusion.
- **Scale:** ranges across both tight-tactical and grand-sprawling.
- **Session:** flexible — short bursts or long marathons, depending.

Dealbreakers

Grind · static builds · solved or “old” games · hideous UI · reflex / APM / twitch demands · long decided-but-not-over tails.

What this predicts (read with the Hard Filters on)

- The **visually-produced** branch of turn-based roguelites — stylized art and clean UI. *Into the Breach* is the archetype: tactical, turn-based, deep, near-unsolvable, and both legible and atmospheric. This is the goldmine. The traditional ASCII-roguelike canon is the decoy that looks identical on a systems spec sheet.

- Builders, economy / management sims, and real-time-with-pause grand strategy — the Anno / CK3 shelf — *where situational variance (maps, seeds, scenarios) keeps re-posing the problem* and the art direction clears the gate.
- Procedurally varied, opaque, single-player systems games — *that also clear the visual gate*.
- Sci-fi 4X and strategy with clean + atmospheric presentation, ideally recent.
- Worth testing: colony / emergent sandboxes with real art direction.

The tension to design around: in this market, the deepest, least-solvable systems usually ship with the poorest presentation — the ASCII roguelikes, the grognard wargames (Shadow Empire). The clean-and-atmospheric games skew more produced, which often means more streamlined and more solvable. Your target is the narrow intersection of deep *and* beautiful *and* deliberate-paced. Any search that matches systems first and checks looks second will overshoot to the ugly-deep pole every time.